
Ancient Roman shipwreck discovered off Sicily coast

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Shipwreck with amphorae hoard discovered off Sicily coast

Italian divers have discovered an ancient Roman shipwreck off the coast of Sicily, believed to be more than 2,000 years old.

The vessel was found piled high with hundreds of well-preserved containers, which were used to transport goods such as wine and olive oil.

Italy's Culture Minister Alessandro Giuli hailed the wreck as “one of the most important underwater archaeological discoveries of recent years”.

Specialist police divers found the ship around 46m (150ft) deep, after a tip-off from fishermen. The wreckage is 21m (69ft) long and 6m (20ft) wide, according to reports in local media.

The culture ministry says it dates from the second or 1st Century BC.

Fisherman and free-diver Giacomo De Mola described stumbling across the historic vessel while surveying the seabed near Mazara del Vallo.

He wrote on social media that he had decided to dive and investigate after seeing something that appeared to be a large rock on his scanner.

“I get closer. And my heart stops. It wasn’t a rock,” he said. Instead, he saw hundreds of amphorae — tall ceramic jars used to store goods in the ancient era, mostly wine, oil or grain.

“This is, without a doubt, the most incredible discovery of my life,” he said. “It’s hard to describe what it feels like to be among the first humans, in nearly 20 centuries, to see that place again.”



Carabinieri via AFP: A diver in full scuba gear on the edge of a small boat in the sea

He posted a video of the wreck, showing eels, snappers and “countless marine life” living among the jars, noting: “The sea never ceases to amaze us. This time we didn’t just find a wreck, we found a piece of our history.”

Specialist divers from the cultural heritage protection arm of Italy’s police, known as the Carabinieri Art Squad, were sent to the site.

Officials say safety measures will be taken to safeguard it while it undergoes investigation, as experts work to determine the nature of the wreck and learn more about its cargo.

The Mediterranean seabed is thought to be scattered with similar ancient wrecks. Another 1st or 2nd Century BC vessel was found north-west of Rome in 2023, again laden with hundreds of amphorae.

In 2018, a Greek merchant ship dating back more than 2,400 years was found lying on its side off the Bulgarian coast. At the time, it was hailed as the world's oldest-known intact shipwreck.

生词标注（都是雅思/新闻高频）

词	词性	中文	备注
shipwreck	n.	沉船；船难	wreck = 残骸
wreckage	n.	（船/飞机）残骸	
vessel	n.	船只	正式词 = ship
amphora (复数 amphorae)	n.	双耳陶罐	古希腊罗马储酒、油、粮用
hail	v.	把……誉为、盛赞	hailed as 被誉为
tip-off	n.	线报、举报	口语色彩，新闻爱用
free-diver	n.	自由潜水者	不带氧气瓶
seabed	n.	海床	
survey	v.	勘测、勘察	名词是”调查/民意测验”
stumble across	短语	偶然发现	不是摔倒
laden	adj.	满载的	load 的形容词形式
scatter	v.	散布、散落	be scattered with 遍布
safeguard	v.	保护	比 protect 正式
undergo	v.	经历、经受	undergo investigation 接受调查
cease	v.	停止	never ceases to = 总能……
intact	adj.	完好无损的	考古类高频词
cargo	n.	货物	船上/飞机上的货
marine life	短语	海洋生物	